CORESTONE
DEVELOPERS

A VETTING GUIDE FOR CUSTOM HOME BUYERS

10 Questions to Ask Any Builder

Before you sign anything. From the team at Corestone.

1 How many homes have you completed in the last three years, and can I see them?

WHY IT MATTERS

Volume proves the operation is real. A builder who can't show recent finished work is asking you to fund their learning curve.

LISTEN FOR

Specific addresses, willingness to arrange drive-bys or tours, pride in the work.

2 Who will actually be on my site every day?

WHY IT MATTERS

The person who sells you the job is rarely the person who builds it. You need to know who runs the site, how long they've been with the company, and whether they're an employee or a subcontractor.

LISTEN FOR

A named project manager or lead carpenter, employed directly, with years on the team.

3 How do you handle pricing: fixed bid, cost-plus, or something else? And what exactly is included?

WHY IT MATTERS

Most budget blowups come from what's excluded, not what's included. Allowances for kitchens, baths, and fixtures are where vague contracts hide real costs.

LISTEN FOR

Detailed line items, realistic allowances based on your finish level, and a clear explanation of what triggers a change order.

4 What's your average cost per square foot for a home at my finish level?

WHY IT MATTERS

Any experienced builder knows their numbers. Evasion here means inexperience or a lowball strategy.

LISTEN FOR

A range with an explanation of what moves it up or down, not a single suspiciously low number.

5 How do you handle changes once construction starts?

WHY IT MATTERS

Changes are inevitable. The question is whether they're documented, priced fairly, and approved by you before the work happens.

LISTEN FOR

A written change-order process, pricing before work begins, no surprises on the invoice.

6 What's your current backlog, and when would my project actually start?

WHY IT MATTERS

A builder who says “we can start next month” either has no work or is overpromising. Realistic timelines are a sign of an honest operation.

LISTEN FOR

A specific start window and an explanation of what's ahead of you.

7 How do you communicate during the build?

WHY IT MATTERS

You'll live with this project for a year or more. Silence breeds anxiety and disputes.

LISTEN FOR

Regular scheduled updates, photos, a single point of contact, and a system (not just “call me anytime”).

8 What happens if something goes wrong after move-in?

WHY IT MATTERS

The warranty conversation tells you everything about how a builder thinks about their work long-term.

LISTEN FOR

A written warranty, a clear process for warranty claims, and examples of standing behind past work.

9 Can I talk to three of your past clients, including one from at least two years ago?

WHY IT MATTERS

Recent clients are still in the honeymoon phase. A client from two years ago will tell you how the builder handles problems.

LISTEN FOR

Immediate yes, with names and numbers. Hesitation is the answer.

10 Why should I build with you instead of the next builder I interview?

WHY IT MATTERS

This is the only sales question on the list, and it's here on purpose. Watch whether they sell or whether they explain.

LISTEN FOR

Specifics about process, team, and track record. Vagueness here after nine good answers is fine. Vagueness as a pattern is not.

CORESTONE

The right builder welcomes these questions.

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